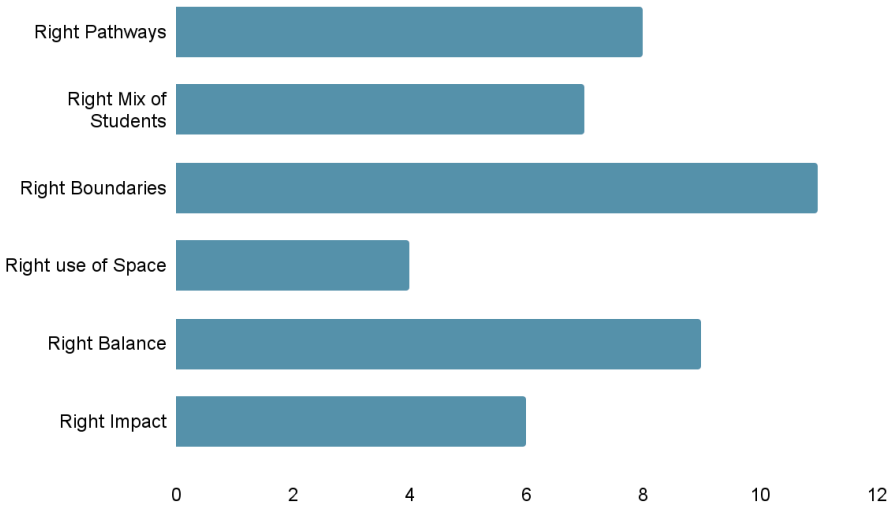
Board Engagement Summary at Benson High School
April 25, 2026

Between 8-15 respondents answered each Slido question during the engagement session held at Benson High School on April 25. While over 10 school communities were represented, Winterhaven K-8 and Alameda Elementary School were the most widely represented schools at this engagement session, and approximately 86% of participants were connected to grades K-5. Approximately 80% of attendees identified as white. Due to the small number of participants, other demographic information is suppressed. Only 13% of families responding had experienced a boundary change in the last five years; an additional 13% experienced their school's grade bands changing. Nearly half (44%) of respondents enrolled their students in focus option programs.

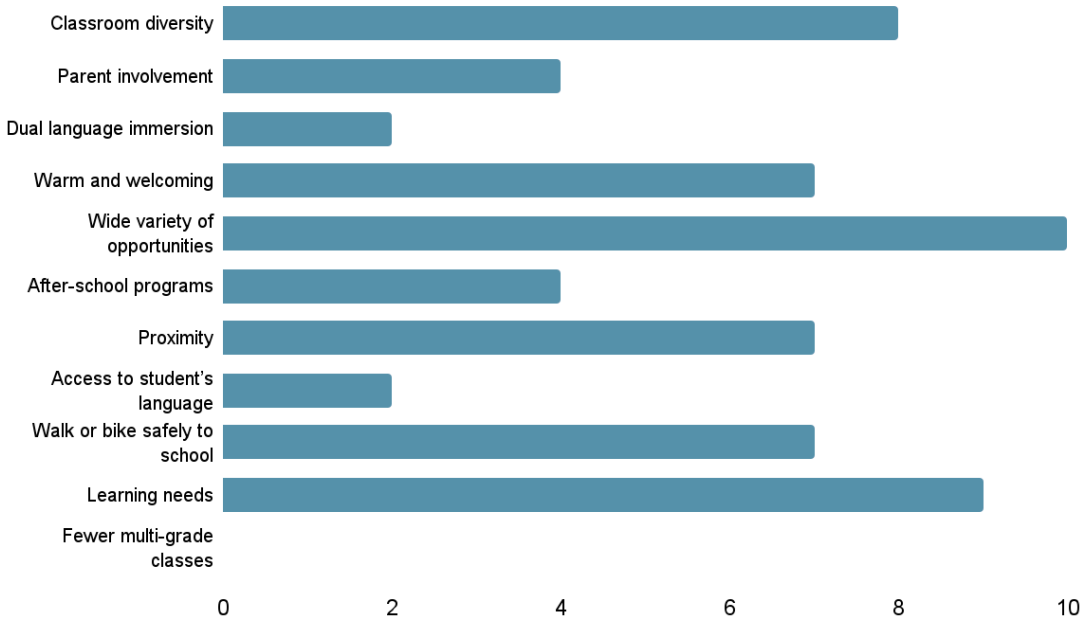
Of the six factors in the PPS student assignment policy, respondents prioritized boundaries that promote safer routes to schools and a sense of community as well as recognize and address natural and human-made barriers, feeder patterns that allows as many students as possible to continue together from one school level to the next, and program and enrollment stability in the surrounding schools over other factors. See Chart 1 for a breakdown of responses to this question.

Chart 1:
Responses to the question, "Our Portland Public Schools Student Assignment Policy asks us to consider the following six factors. Please select the three most important factors to consider during program and enrollment balancing across our system." (15 responses)



When asked to rank four factors that make a positive school environment, respondents identified a wide variety of learning opportunities, access to services that meet every student's learning needs, learning alongside children from different backgrounds, ability of children who live close together to attend the same school, and access to services that meet every student's learning needs (including special education as the highest priorities. See Chart 2 for a breakdown of responses to this question.

Chart 2:
Responses to the question, "select the top four factors that you think make a positive school environment" (15 responses)



Nine (9) respondents answered the question, "What has helped you/your student feel connected as they move from one school to the next?" Families shared that welcoming teachers and proactive outreach from counselors and other school staff helped students acclimate to new learning environments. Beyond staff support, the greatest sense of security comes from consistency and attending school with established friends and neighbors.

Overall, feedback from this listening session emphasized that neighborhood schools act as community hubs and expressed fear that the closure of any neighborhood schools would erode trust and lower property values. When thinking about remaking school boundaries, participants encouraged prioritizing underprivileged families and neighborhood proximity. Prioritizing stable, desirable local options is the only way to stop the loss of enrollment to the suburbs or private institutions.